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Bill Kirchner

Bill Kirchner was born in 1953 in Youngstown, Ohio. He has made a mark in the jazz world as a saxophonist, composer/arranger, jazz historian, producer, educator, and radio personality. Bill's most creative work has been performed and recorded by the Bill Kirchner Nonet. He remains active as an educator and composer despite the onset of significant physical limitations.

Bill was interviewed via Zoom on June 4, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'm very pleased to have Bill Kirchner with me today. And I had the little stumbling block of how to start with you because I've been reading some of the interviews you've done and most people say a similar thing and that's you've worn so many hats, which hat should I concentrate on?

BK: I couldn't begin to tell you that. I'm the worst person to ask.

MR: Yes exactly. But I did want — I had a thought — I do some arranging and I have over the years, in fact our career paths have some similarities. And I'm currently working on an arrangement. And on the way up today in the car it was going through my head, sort of what to do next, where am I, how am I going to end it. And I wonder if it's something similar for you when you're working on a piece of music. Is it constantly in your head until you finish it?

BK: Interesting question. Yes, short answer. Yeah I think it becomes something almost like an obsession. And sometimes, I don't have a car anymore but I remember when I did have a car I remember some of the best ideas I got was when I was in the car, or you know, other bizarre places like in the shower or whatever you know. The ideas come when they come and there's no predicting that.

MR: Isn't that so interesting, you don't have to be sitting at the piano or score paper or Finale or whatever, they just seem to have this way of presenting themselves. And I know I've lost some ideas — walking the dog and I get this idea and yeah, by the time I get home it may be gone.

BK: Well you know Duke Ellington used to carry a little notebook on him at all times so he could write down ideas when they came to him, no matter when they came or where he was when they came, which I think is a good idea, especially if you were Duke Ellington.

MR: When you, let's suppose I commissioned you to write a chart on a song that's been done to death — let's say "All of Me." For some reason I want an arrangement of "All of Me" for a full sized jazz ensemble. Can you describe — and maybe you say, "What about

something else." No, I'm insistent, I want "All of Me." Can you tell me how you might approach this trying to get something different out of this tune?

BK: Well I should point out as part of this, are you familiar with Fred Sturm's book? Composing/arranging book?

MR: Somewhat, yes.

BK: He did that very thing. He commissioned a bunch of great arrangers to do charts on "All of Me" including Manny Albam and Bob Brookmeyer and Bill Holman and others. And they all came up with different slants on it, some of them outrageously outside, like Brookmeyer. So it's interesting that you should mention that, and pick that particular tune, because indeed it's been done for precisely the reason that you're talking about. Anyway to try to answer your question, I guess I would begin by asking about the band that I was writing for, about the people who were playing, what their strengths and weaknesses are, what their interests are, what they do best. That would give me a clue about how to approach it and, you know, the more personal that you can get the better off you are and the more distinctive your end product is going to be I think. So that's where I would start is just asking who are your best soloists, what do they do best? And then take it from there. I remember about twenty-some years ago I got a commission from the U.S. Air Force Airmen of Note. They said Pete BarenBregge, who was the leader of the band at the time, you know, just gave me a commission and said, "Write whatever you want." And so I mean we're talking about a band in this case that's been in existence since 1950 that has a book of thousands of charts. And I said, "Well what don't you have a lot of?" And he said, "Shuffles." So I ended up doing a kind of a jazz-rock shuffle. And so I mean that's an example of just trying to find something that worked for them that they would have use for that hadn't been done to death. And it came out pretty well, at least I was happy with it. I don't know if they ever play it but I've had several performances of it otherwise with various college bands here and in Europe since then, and they played it well, so I know it worked.

MR: I would have been so happy if that had been me because I dearly love a shuffle.

BK: Yeah, sure. It's kind of an infectious groove but you know it's very rhythmic. I mean the whole point of the thing is rhythm of course.

MR: Well that anticipated a question, because you were assigned a groove so to speak. What comes next? Does the melody come next or the chord sequence or the form?

BK: Well you know what I did? In 1989 and '91 I spent two years studying with Bob Brookmeyer and Manny Albam in the BMI Jazz Composers' Workshop. And they taught us a technique called "Pitch Modules" where you take three note pitch cells and use it to develop raw material from which to write music. And I teach it to all my composing/arranging students and I tell them, tongue in cheekedly, that using this

technique is much better than waiting to break-up with your significant other for an inspiration. So in this case, when I wrote this chart for the Airmen of Note, and often when I'm writing, you know, original music, I'll use this "Pitch Module" technique just to develop raw material. And it can, from that can arise melodies or harmonies. You can use these rows of notes that come from the pitch module to derive whatever you want, in essence. So in essence what happened with that chart, the Airmen of Note, is I came up with the melody and I came up with some countermelodies and I came up with some harmonies as a result. So after you do the work you go through and just find stuff that you like and let nature take its course.

MR: Can I assume that somewhere along the line you moved, when writing scores, from a score paper pad to Finale or Sibelius or something like that?

BK: Ut uh. I can't write on the computer. I still have to write on score paper, and then I have a copyist quote unquote who's adept on you know Finale and Sibelius who then, I'll just give the score to and he can load it in for me. I mean I know a number of composers and arrangers who are like me, who have just never made the transition.

MR: Yeah, I don't know if you know Dave Rivello at Eastman?

BK: Oh, Dave and I are both from Youngstown, Ohio.

MR: I'll be darned.

BK: We held — our first arranging teacher was Sam DeAngelo who was my high school band director, rest his soul. He died a couple of years ago. But Dave and I had Sam for our first arranging teacher.

MR: I went to his house to interview him and I was so pleased to see he had this whole setup with, you know, a big like draftsman table and he had the score paper and so I asked him about that. He said, "Well there's something about the physical act of choosing a note with a pencil and putting it on the paper. It's like you're much more committed than just putting something with a mouse that you can easily go back and take away I guess."

BK: Well in my case I'm a techno-putz. So I just can't deal with the idea of having some mechanical thing be between me and the act of putting the notes on the score you know. If I lose an idea because I'm fumbling with trying to do the mechanics then I've lost something and I don't want to take that chance. I don't know, I have a low frustration threshold with stuff like that. I tried to learn Finale and I tried to learn Sibelius and it just drove me nuts. I just couldn't handle it.

MR: Well as we go along we have more and more in common. I want to take you back, you mentioned Mr. DeAngelo, and can you recall the feeling or your reaction to the first time you heard one of your early arrangements played?

BK: Oh yeah. I wrote my first big band chart for Sam when I was in high school. We had a quote stage band. And he was a piano player and an arranger and he wrote charts for the

band on things like "Comin' Home Baby" and "So What." I mean this was late 60s, early 70s. And I mean for the time, that was very hip for any kind of school band, college or high school. I mean this was a high school band. So the fact that he was writing charts for us was, this was so cool. So I got interested in writing and he encouraged me to write and I wrote this chart on "A Taste of Honey," you know the Bobby Scott tune? So that was my first chart for a big band. And we played it and it wasn't bad. I mean I didn't know a lot about voicing for horns and stuff like that, but I knew enough to come up with something that sounded halfway decent. And it was a great thrill you know, you can imagine, you come up with something like that that's your own, it's a whole new part of you that you didn't know you had and like bam, there it is.

MR: Did any of the players in the band provide some feedback like, "I can't play that. That's really awkward."

BK: No, no, nothing. Everything seemed to lay okay. Nobody said anything to the contrary to me anyway.

MR: Okay. Was there something, I read an anecdote about you hearing the Ellington band and how much an impression — I'm also wondering if there was something in your household, LPs or radio or something that helped set you on your eventual path?

BK: Well do you want me to tell the story about the Ellington band etcetera, etcetera? Shall I start there?

MR: Well yeah, I'm more curious because I've been interested in how every generation has their high tech things that their entertainment is delivered through. And when we think back to, you and I are close in age and if we think back to our formative years, the high tech at that time, so what was in your household that you might have heard music from?

BK: Well I mean aside from television, in the late 50s if you recall there was a sudden surge of jazz oriented scores for TV cop shows, like "Peter Gunn," "Mr. Lucky," "Johnny Staccato," "Checkmates," all these forgotten TV shows that people like Henry Mancini and John Williams and Pete Rugolo and Johnny Mandel and others were writing scores for. So I heard this music, beginning with "Peter Gunn" when I was about five years old and this was some of the first music I can remember hearing and some of the first jazz I can remember hearing. And it all just hit me remarkably hard. Just the harmony, all these hip harmonies, and the rhythms of course, and of course all these scores were played by some of the hippest jazz musicians in LA at the time. So that was a big exposure to jazz and to music, and also my parents were very low tech. I mean they didn't even have LPs until I got seriously interested in music and they finally bought a stereo, you know, to play LPs. But for much of my childhood all we had was the 45 RPM record player to play. So they had a handful of 45s, Glenn Miller things, Tex Beneke, you know. Actually there was a, do you remember a piano player named Lou Stein?

MR: I do not.

BK: He was a really good jazz piano player who was active in the 40s, 50s, until maybe twenty years ago, active in New York, played with a lot of people. And one of the 45s that my mother had was the thing that Lou had, it was kind of a fluke hit called "Soft Sands." And so I remember playing that a lot of times and I memorized the melody and could play it on my horns, on clarinet to begin with. So fast forward, oh God, 'til the late 1980s and I end up on this club date, by club date I'm using the musician's term, you know weddings, bar mitzvahs, private parties, that sort. So I ended up on a club date in Connecticut with Lou Stein. So we were in the middle of this gig and we're just playing dinner music or something. And I said, "Could we play 'Soft Sands'?" I thought his jaw was going to hit the floor you know. It was great fun. So we played "Soft Sands." You know I'm sure he'd never gotten a request for that in his life.

MR: I'll be darned. That's a great moment. What about radio? Did it have any impact on you?

BK: Oh yeah. Well my parents would listen to the radio every morning when we were getting ready for school and all that stuff, and it was AM radio at the time. I mean the stations they listened to, my parents were very non-rock & roll. They listened to mainstream adult pop music. So I mean they would have on the radio what the records of the time were, maybe Sinatra things or Tony Bennett or Barbra Streisand, or whatever was in the air at the time. So I got exposed to a lot of that. And you know I mean I had good ears and a good retentive memory so I could end up playing these things on my horn and kind of absorbing stuff that was in the air and then eventually, I guess that's what generated my interest in arranging was just hearing all this stuff on the radio, a lot of which was backed by big band.

MR: Can I guess that your parents looked askance at a music career?

BK: Good guess. Oh yeah. I mean no they didn't want me to have a career as a musician, although I mean they did encourage my interest in music. I mean they paid for music lessons for me for years, and I should tell this story, going back to the Ellington. In 1965 I was just short of my twelfth birthday and I had this neophyte's interest in jazz. So there was a three day jazz festival in Pittsburgh at the civic arena that George Wein was producing. And Pittsburgh is about an hour or so's drive from Youngstown. So for my upcoming twelfth birthday my parents gave me an early birthday present and said we'll take you to this festival on a Saturday night. So we went to Pittsburgh to the civic arena, and the bill for the one night, it was a Saturday night, the opening act was this local guy, a piano player named Walt Harper with his group; and then Earl Hines with a trio; Carmen McRae with Norman Simmons' trio; Stan Getz's quartet with Gary Burton, Steve Swallow and Roy Haynes; John Coltrane's quartet with McCoy Tyner, Jimmy Garrison and Elvin Jones; and the Ellington band with Billy Strayhorn as a guest because

Strayhorn was from Pittsburgh, as was Earl Hines. So this was kind of a homecoming for both of them. So this was the bill for one night. And I mean that was the night that basically set me on my career path, even though my parents didn't realize it at the time nor would they have approved if they'd known it, but I mean that really set me on my career path I mean as far as solidifying a serious interest in jazz. Up to that point I'd been doing my best to listen to top 40 radio to conform to the interest of my schoolmates. But after that top 40 radio just went down the toilet. I couldn't care less after that. I started using whatever allowance money I had to buy LPs. My parents bought a stereo that I could play the LPs on, and other than that, you know there were some syndicated jazz radio shows like Sid Mark in Philadelphia had a syndicated jazz radio show that I would listen to on Saturday nights. And there was a 50,000 watt clear channel station in Rochester, New York, WHAM, that had a five hour jazz show from midnight to five in the morning that I would listen to on my transistor radio, especially when I was on holidays from school. I would just lie in bed with my transistor. This is late 60s, early 70s. And there were two different DJs. The first guy was a guy named Bill Ardis, and then his successor was a guy named Harry Abraham. And they played really hip stuff, you know whatever the new LP releases were. I mean I heard, I remember one night I was listening to the radio and this kind of funk type thing came on and I was wondering what is this? Is this Cannonball Adderley or something? And it turned out to be Miles Davis from "Miles in the Sky" doing that tune called "Stuff" which was the first time Herbie Hancock recorded on a Fender Rhodes. So I heard that on Harry Abraham's show. So I heard, I guess at that point I had found outlets that were — even in Youngstown, Ohio I could hear what was going on.

MR: In retrospect, at the risk of sounding, you know, oh back in my day, there was something magical about finding these things. And you know you had a little transistor radio and saving up money to get LPs and then reading the liner notes as you listen to the record. It was like a whole experience.

BK: Oh yeah. Yeah for sure. Well including the liner notes. I mean written by people like, well also I started reading *DownBeat*. You know I was reading all this stuff by people like Dan Morgenstern and Ira Gitler and Martin Williams, all of whom later became friends and colleagues of mine. So that was a big part of my education was reading this stuff that these people and others were writing at the time.

MR: It's interesting that you heard John Coltrane at that point in your life. I believe I read something where you were talking about early on you were trying to do the John Coltrane thing but you had no direction to it. I'm not sure that's the exact quote.

BK: Close enough. No I was just trying to play as many notes as I could with no real sense of, you know, I mean I certainly didn't understand Coltrane's harmonic concept at the time. I

mean I was just trying to play a lot of notes. So when I got to New York in 1971 and I started studying with Lee Konitz, the very first lesson I went to leave for, and I studied with him for two years, he handed me a Frank Sinatra album, "Songs for Swinging Lovers" and he said, "Okay take this home and learn to sing along with Sinatra, exactly the way he sings, on one of these tunes, with all the inflections and the rhythmic feel and whatever. And it's a great exercise for anybody. I mean all his life, and I knew Lee, we were friends until he died basically. For his practice routine for the rest of his life, I mean he would sing along with Sinatra records. That was an important part of his practice routine. And it's a great exercise. It gets you away from the horn and just puts you kind of in direct contact with the music without any instrument between you and the music.

MR: For me it begs the question, sometimes you read comments about jazz and I think they're usually written, not the musician writers, the non-musician writers, who say jazz musicians play what they feel. And I've had this debate with myself about how much emotion is connected to improvisation. Is it driven by emotion and feeling or is it driven by more theoretical knowledge? I know what chord I'm playing here and I know that this will sound out, this will sound in. I'm not sure that's a question but it's — I'll let you try to deal with it.

BK: Yeah I probably, my answer would be it's all of the above. I mean certainly emotion should have an important bearing on it because if it isn't then why are we doing it? But also I mean you have to have a solid either theoretical knowledge or some kind of instinctual thing about the music. I mean somebody, there are some great players like for example Chet Baker knew nothing about harmony in a theoretical sense but he had great ears. So you know I mean he had his own kind of knowledge. You know it was an instinctual thing and it wasn't based on music theory but it was knowledge nonetheless. So you know if you have the instinctual knowledge or the theoretical knowledge of some sort combined with the emotional thing, that that's where substantial music comes from I would think. That's been my experience anyway.

MR: In the years, let's say the early 70s, I think you had returned to New York.

BK: I went for the first time. I went to college in New York from '71 to '75.

MR: Okay. Did you go to clubs as often as you could afford let's say, and do you recall hearing any particular group or individual that just sort of blew you away?

BK: Everything man. I mean look I arrived in New York in the fall of 1971 and in the first six months I was in New York I can tell you who I heard. And you have to remember that I went to clubs as much as I could on my limited college kid's budget. But there was also a lot of free stuff going on, free meaning no charge. But the first six months I heard Lee Konitz playing with a minimalist named Lamont Young in the Metropolitan Museum actually; then I heard Elvin Jones' quartet in a little auditorium on the upper west side

with Joe Farrell and Dave Liebman and Gene Perla; I heard the Thad Jones-Mel Lewis band at the Village Vanguard, this was the first of a number of times I heard them at the Vanguard; I heard Chick Corea and Return to Forever, their first gig at the Village Vanguard, this was the Return to Forever with Joe Farrell and Flora Purim and Stanley Clarke, and I heard Airto Moreira, this was their first gig ever and it was one of the greatest nights of live music I have ever heard, as good as the records were that they made. In person they were just stunning. I heard Charles Mingus' all-star big band at Philharmonic Hall with Lee Konitz, Gerry Mulligan, Gene Ammons, Milt Hinton, Joe Chambers, Jon Faddis. I heard Sonny Rollins at the Vanguard with Albert Dailey, Larry Ridley and David Lee. This was the first six months you know. And then after that well I was in school. There was a lot of, as I said, there were a lot of free concerts going on. There was this place on 55th Street called the New York Jazz Museum that opened up while I was in college. They would have Sunday afternoon concerts for free. And I heard a bunch of people there. I heard Howard McGhee and Joe Carroll. I heard Hank Mobley. I heard Thad and Mel with the quintet with Billy Harper and George Mraz and Walter Norris. Jimmy Guiffre. You know this was all for free you know. You could just go on a Sunday afternoon.

MR: Were you ever tempted at that time to call up Mom and Dad and say, "Listen, I'm not going to major anymore in what I'm doing, I have to be a musician."

BK: No. I didn't have the guts. Plus I was, you know, this was my excuse for being in New York. So I mean I was studying with Konitz for a couple of years and then I started studying for a couple of years with Harold Danko, who by the way is also from Youngstown, Ohio, although I used to play outdoor concerts with his older brothers who were both saxophone players. We would play concert band gigs in Youngstown. And I didn't meet Harold until 1973 when we were both in New York. He had just gotten off Woody Herman's band. So I got his number and I called him and we hooked up and had an instant friendship. We're really good friends 'til this day. And I started studying with him and it was perfect because I had stopped studying with Lee because basically, without saying so I think Lee had come to the point where we couldn't, there was nothing more he could teach me or felt that he could teach me. And I felt like I still had so much to learn. And luckily I met Harold just at that moment and it was perfect because I desperately needed some basic piano chops, you know, how to voice chords, 2-5-1s and things like that. And Harold was perfect because he's a great teacher. And he would go anywhere you wanted to go. He had no preconceived notions of anything. So he was the perfect teacher for me that I needed at precisely that moment. So I studied with him for two years and it was great.

MR: It seems that your career has been a series of opportunities that came up that you managed to step into and succeed. If you went to a gathering, a cocktail party or something, and it was just a brief conversation with somebody you really didn't know and they said, "What do you do?" Do you have like a brief answer?

BK: My elevator moment?

MR: Thank you for, yes, that would do.

BK: Or they say something you could tell people in the course of an elevator ride.

MR: Yeah.

BK: Well my stock response is I'm a saxophone player, a composer/arranger, a band leader, a jazz historian, a radio producer, a record producer, and an educator.

MR: Okay.

BK: That's, all of which I've done — and I'd like to think that I've done all those things on a world class level. I mean, which is not, I'm not making myself into some kind of uber-mensch. I mean I could point to any one of those things and tell you oodles of people who do any one of those things better than I can. But nonetheless I've managed to do stuff in all of those categories that is on a world class level, so that's something I'm proud of.

MR: As you should be. And that would have gotten you to the fourth floor and that person would have learned a lot I think.

BK: Hope so.

MR: Yeah. What is the, what stands out in your mind — this is sort of a two part question. And people have asked me this question and I have a hard time answering, but do you recall both the worst musical situation or gig you've ever been in, and the best.

BK: Oh man. Well the worst, there are so many that they're beyond enumerating.

MR: Really?

BK: Well, well, well I mean in the 80s I used to do a lot of commercial gigs, club dates you know, where you would just get hired and you would just be sent out to play with some kind of ad hoc pick up band doing a wedding or a bar mitzvah or a private party. And so many of those things were just so dreadful you know, in terms of I mean the music sucked, it was frightfully loud, just everything about it was blah. So I mean there were so many of those that are beyond recall. I mean I remember some of the worst of them but the rest I've just kind of blanked out, just out of self defense.

MR: Can I ask you one thing about that? Do you recall the pay scale for those, are you talking about maybe in the 80s?

BK: Yeah. When I came back, after I went to college I went to DC for five years and was there for five years and then I came back to New York in 1980 and I started just, because it was work I made some phone calls and I started doing these club dates in addition to

whatever jazz playing I was doing, rehearsing with bands or playing little jazz gigs, or I started putting together my own nonet. But I remember in 1980 for a four hour Saturday night club date the scale was 96 dollars. By the time I quit doing those gigs, about in the early 90s the scale was up to about 200 dollars for a Saturday night.

MR: And that's a union scale?

BK: Yeah. That's a Local 802 club date scale for a four hour Saturday night. Four hour continuous as they say.

MR: Now if a person, if a young woman calls you and says, "I'm getting married, I got your name, can you play" — and all the details. Is this something that you were required to go through the union to do?

BK: No. I mean I worked, at the time there were these different club date offices that would just hire you and send you out to play with these ad hoc bands. Some of them were people that I worked with on a fairly steady basis and some of them were just one nighters, people I'd never seen before. But I would just go where I was told to go. But anyway, to answer the other part of your question, the best gigs I've ever done, I'm lucky in that several of them by serendipitously were recorded and have come out on CD. I mean one of them is doing the Chicago Jazz Festival in 1987 with my nonet and Sheila Jordan as a guest vocalist. I mean that's on CD now. I sent you a link that that on YouTube. Another one is a concert that my nonet did at the Smithsonian in 1990 that is on a two CD set called "Trance Dance." Yet another is a concert that the nonet did at the New School in 2001 that's on CD, that's called "Lifeline." Still another is a duo concert that I did with Marc Copland at the New School in 2008, that's on a CD called "Old Friends." And then the last one is a concert at the New School in 2014 with Carlton Holmes on piano and Jim Ferguson is a great singer and bass player from Nashville and the late Holli Ross who was a wonderful singer who died a year or so ago of cancer, far too young by the way. So that's on CD. That's another thing called "An Evening of Indigos." So I've been very lucky that some of the best nights of my career have been recorded well and are, and they came out great performance-wise, and they're available on CD. So I've been exceptionally lucky in that respect.

MR: I'm happy to hear that all the best gigs you mentioned were with your own arrangements and, you know, like sort of you being in charge. And I think that speaks well of your career also. A while back I watched a documentary on Quincy Jones. And you know I've been a fan, like most people, of the majority of his work and —

BK: I saw that.

MR: Yeah. And I may have missed it, but he never was asked where do your ideas come from. And this is sort of a follow up of the "All of Me" question that we did a half an hour ago,

but when you go to write an original work, or even arrangements, can you, maybe it's an unanswerable question but can you tell me where your ideas come from?

BK: Well in part from that pitch module process that I told you about, where I just generate some raw material you know to come up with ideas. Other times I've written a couple of pieces that were just from a person's name, you know that you could play the notes on the piano and come up with a melody from a person's name and then from that generated a melody. I just use these kind of artificial devices. And then other times they've just been just sheer inspiration. It varies. I've learned to embrace inspiration when it presents itself but when it doesn't I've come up with, I've learned to use these kind of artificial devices that enable me to come up with raw material so that I'm not sitting there staring at the keyboard hoping for inspiration to write.

MR: Have you ever written something then you're like excited about it only to find out that someone else wrote it already? That you're unconsciously channeling some other melody?

BK: No.

MR: Well that's good. Because I have.

BK: Okay. No I guess I don't mean to sound egocentric about this but I know a hell of a lot of recorded music so the chances of something coming up that I haven't heard or, at this point in my life, are pretty slim you know. I've been listening to recorded music since I was four or five years old. And I've checked out a lot of stuff, a huge amount of stuff. So I mean I have a very keen sense of what's out there and what's been done. I mean one of the things when I'm teaching jazz courses, whether it's jazz history or composing or arranging or ensembles or whatever is that I try to give students an idea of what's been done. I play the recordings of great whatever, of great soloing, of great writing, of, you know whatever, just so that they get a chance of what's been done so that they're not reinventing the wheel.

MR: Do you ever give them assignments to purposely reinvent the wheel?

BK: No, no. I always encourage them to do their own thing as best they can.

MR: I think you mentioned something I read that the current generation of aspiring young jazz artists not only have to be good improvisers with their instruments, they have to improvise their career. How do we make up for the fact that the jam sessions and the small club gigs and the touring bands are mostly a thing of the past?

BK: Well I wouldn't say that the small club gigs, I mean there are still sessions, I mean my students here in New York, well prior to the pandemic of course, but there are still these clubs like Small's in New York where students get together and do their little gigs and play. And there are still plenty of sessions. I mean a lot of it is now through the veneer of education I guess. I mean it used to be the jazz apprenticeship system for decades and

decades was a really important thing where you had, you know, great established musicians who would hire young guys, and now young women we can say, to play with them and give them seasoning. But now that the jazz apprenticeship system is almost entirely defunct a lot of it now is mentorship that's done through the schools. I know I've taken some students kind of under my wing and done stuff with them and for them, and I know lots of my colleagues have done the same thing. So now it's done through the schools. But it's still done. I mean there's X amount of work that's got to be done, there's X amount of experience that these kids have to have somehow or other because I mean very few people, you know, when they're very young are totally mature and seasoned. I mean that's extremely rare. They've got to get experience and chops and maturity through whatever means possible and so however you do it you've got to do it.

MR: Okay. When you put your nonet together, was there a consideration, perhaps you're thinking to yourself how many wind instruments do I need to do the kinds of voicings that I want to do, and then from a practical sense balance it with the idea that it's going to be hard to get nine people, ten, twelve people together consistently.

BK: Okay so your question is what specifically?

MR: How did you arrive at nine?

BK: Well Sam DeAngelo and I had done a band of that size when we were in Youngstown, we did, I used to go back home during the summer to work in factories and whatever, making some money for college. And also, so the summer of 1974 which was just before my senior year in college we decided to put this band together which was basically a nonet plus a vibes player, it was ten pieces. So we came up with a similar instrumentation. It was trumpet, French horn, valve trombone, three reeds, one of whom was Ralph LaLama by the way, he was in college at the time at Youngstown State University, that's where I first met him; and another was Harold Danko's older brother Joe playing baritone. So anyway we did a few park concerts, you know, Music Performance Trust Fund concerts, so we did a couple of those and so I had that book. So when I came to New York I had that book and I decided to get together a rehearsal and just play some of those charts. So I rewrote a few of the charts with slightly different instrumentation done, so it ended up being two trumpets, doubling flugelhorns, bass trombone, three reeds with a lot of doubles, and three rhythm. And just — six horns for me was a good size. It gave you enough horns to basically duplicate just about any voicing you wanted to do, and also with having two trumpets, having the second trumpet underneath the lead trumpet makes a big difference with writing ensemble tuttis, it gives a lot of additional support that you don't have when you only have one trumpet. So that ended up being my instrumentation of choice. And also, you know I mean it was the best of all possible worlds for me. It was — you could have enough fire power to come up

with like a big band punch if you wanted it, but at the same time it gave you the advantage of being a hip small group when you wanted that as well. And there were a lot of different colors with all the doubles and everything. That was really important, having all those doubles.

MR: If I looked at a nonet score and I looked at beat one of measure four, like everybody's playing, maybe like two or three beats, could I discern what the chord is for the most part, in your writing?

BK: I suppose.

MR: I think what I'm trying —

BK: I suppose, I mean if you're an educated musician like you are, yeah, I would imagine you could. Not all the time. I mean sometimes we just write things that — as Herbie Hancock said, we just, it's hard to put names on these things, they're just sounds.

MR: They are sounds.

BK: You know. But I think for the most part you could come up with some kind of nomenclature that would describe what the chord was. But with some of the more outside things perhaps not.

MR: What constitutes outside for you? I had this sort of a similar question I was going to bring up about the thought process in your head when you're improvising. Bill Watrous said yeah you can play outside but you better know what you're outside of, and you ought to be able to bring it back inside, or something like that.

BK: Yeah. That's a really great comment. Yeah, well the people who know what they're doing, you know, like Coltrane would go outside, say Coltrane would play a tune like "Impressions" you know, like which is D minor and then E flat minor for the bridge. I mean he would go outside of the modes, outside of D minor for X amount of time, but his voice leading was so good that he would, you know, he would play outside of those basic modes but come back in after a certain point just to re-establish that he knew what he was doing and he knew how to create dissonance but he knew how to come back in to just obey the laws of good voice leading, let's put it that way. I mean there are some people who I've heard play quote outside who really don't know what they're doing. They're just playing notes that are deliberately dissonant just for the sense of creating dissonance but they really don't understand the theory behind it. Like for example there's a great book by Dave Liebman called *A Chromatic Approach to Jazz Harmony and Melody*, where it's a book basically about how to play outside but with theoretical knowledge. And you know I mean he talks about things like that, he and Richie Beirach were pioneers in that kind of outside kind of playing but with really good theoretical knowledge. And those are people who know how to play outside but do so with — that it

makes musical sense. And there's a logic to it, it's not just haphazard or half-assed or, you know, there's a musicality to it.

MR: Okay. Let me run a couple of names by you, see if you have anything to opine about. Cannonball Adderley.

BK: Oh one of my favorite players. Wonderful player you know. I heard him, I heard his band with Nat live at a festival in Cleveland in the late 60s, you know the band with Joe Zawinul and Victor Gaskin and Roy McCurdy. I mean part of the fun of Cannonball, I mean he was so good with audiences. I mean when you listen to live Cannonball records they usually kept his audience raps on there and you could hear how good he was — he was a former school teacher so he really connected with audiences on a, not just a musical level but on a very personal level as well. And he was such a great player. I mean I think it's only been in the past couple of decades that people have really been giving him his due for how good he really was. He was a staggeringly good player.

MR: He surely was, and I have — just last week I was playing some of his last recordings, and he could go fairly out himself when he wanted to.

BK: Well he spent two years standing next to Coltrane with Miles. I mean when you listen to hit records of his that he made after he played with Coltrane for a couple of years there's a, you know there's a real Coltrane influence in his playing. Like you know the album called "Mercy Mercy Mercy?"

MR: Oh yes.

BK: There's a tune on there called "Fun."

MR: Yeah. Right after "Games," just before "Games," right?

BK: Yeah, but on "Fun" I mean there's a real Coltrane influence on some of the lines that he plays and some of the harmonies that he uses. He learned a lot from Coltrane. He was a very smart guy so it was impossible for him not to pick up a lot when he was with Miles and Coltrane.

MR: What about Gil Evans?

BK: One of my favorite writers. I had one experience with him by the way, about a year before he died. This was the summer of '87. It was a Monday morning and I was just lying in bed. The phone rings and I hear this voice at the other end of the phone, "This is Gil Evans," who I'd never met before. He said, "Maria Schneider gave me your number. I'm doing a rehearsal this afternoon and I need a sub for Howard Johnson on baritone and bass clarinet. Can you do it? I'll pay you." And I resisted the temptation to say, "No, it's okay I'll pay you." So I grabbed my baritone and bass clarinet and I go downtown to the west 20s and I walked into this studio and guys are just standing around warming up, whatever. And I look around and I see this tall, good looking guy who looked vaguely familiar. And I looked at him for about a minute and I realized this was Sting. And what

this was, this was a rehearsal of Gil's band plus Sting as a guest soloist, they were going to go to the Umbria Jazz Festival. So what we rehearsed was — Maria and Tom Malone had written some charts on Police tunes like "Synchronicity" and "Roxanne." And they had a few charts in Gil's book from that Jimi Hendrix album that he had done in the 70s. Those charts were not written by Gil by the way, they were by somebody else. And they were really not much, frankly. That album is not one of Gil's great records. But anyway so I did the rehearsal and he gave me 40 bucks, two 20 dollar bills. I should have kept them but I didn't I spent them like an idiot. But that was my one experience with Gil. And Sting was great, he was a sweet guy and totally there for the music, no ego, no rock star pretentions, he was just one of the guys, he was there for the music. So it was a nice little experience.

MR: Nice. I don't think I would have —

BK: Aside from that I mean Gil is one of my big influences as a writer and I know I'm far from alone in that respect. But I mean from the time when — I was still in high school when I first heard "Miles Ahead" and from then on I became a huge Gil Evans fan.

MR: Yeah, thank you for those answers. Has your melody conception changed over the years? You lost the use of your right arm and the fact that you managed to keep playing but in a different way, did it affect the way you think about melodies?

BK: Yeah. Well I had my soprano, after I had my — I had surgery in 1993 that left my — to remove a spinal tumor that was life-threatening so that left my right hand basically crippled. I mean I have only a very limited use of my right hand so the only horn I could still play of the nine saxophones and flutes and clarinets I've played at one point, the only one I could still play was soprano saxophone. So I had a repairman, Perry Ritter, who is a great repairman, he rebuilt the horn with alternate keys so I could still play. But I guess as a result, you know I mean Lee Konitz one afternoon about eight or ten years ago Lee and I got together for lunch and we just went over to his apartment and just played improvised duets, just calling tunes for an hour or two. And he said something that I'll never forget. He said, "You can always simplify." And that's one of the hippest bits of advice I've ever heard from an improvising musician. You can always simplify, and it's true. I mean I only have a fraction of the facility on the horn that I used to, so as an improviser I've just learned to play simpler because I have to. For example, that record I did, the duo record I did with Marc Copland in 2008 called "Old Friends" I mean that's just the two of us playing tunes that we like to play. And the track, I sent that to you, the tracks are long, man. I mean they're anywhere from ten to fifteen minutes long for a duo. So I mean playing simpler doesn't mean that you can't play for a long period of time. You just learn to pace yourself in a different way. But I mean we just did that concert and you know just with as much spontaneity as possible. And after it was done I was

staggered at how long the tracks were. And I'd like to think that they're not boring or not going on past their bedtime. But they're really extended and it's just the two of us. So I mean you learn to pace yourself in a different way.

MR: Thank you for that. We've been at this for over an hour so I have two more questions. I saw you perform at Joe Wilder's memorial service.

BK: Oh yeah. 2014. With Bill Charlap.

MR: Pardon?

BK: With Bill Charlap.

MR: Yes. It was very touching and lovely. And I wonder, being friends or associating with gentlemen like Joe from his generation, I've had this most marvelous fortunate experience to have a few associations. I wonder what you learned from those guys?

BK: Oh man, well in Joe's case I mean Joe was the quintessential gentleman in every respect, just the sweetest man and an extraordinary player. But I mean just the way he carried himself. Always had a suit and tie on you know? I mean just the epitome of class, as was somebody else I was fortunate to be able to call a friend and that was Benny Carter, who I got to be good friends with for 25 years. And guys like that, I mean they were just so cool and such great musicians and such great classy people. You know I mean they just lived their lives in such a remarkable way. I mean you couldn't help, if you had any kind of radar at all you couldn't help learning stuff from them just because they were great natural teachers. And they set such a great example for so many people. And you know with guys like that, when they came up I mean that was at the height of segregated racist America, I mean some of the stuff that they experienced was frightening I'm sure, but they never let it get them down. They always managed to overcome whatever obstacles that they faced, and triumphed and had great careers and made an enormous difference in the lives of so many of us. I mean for example Benny Carter helped to integrate the two AFM locals in Los Angeles in the early 50s. They combined the black and white locals into one local and Benny was one of the ringleaders in making that come about. So I mean that's just an example of the impact that he had that went beyond purely musical. But Joe was, I mean he was such a nice man. Always had his camera too.

MR: Yes.

BK: He was a great photographer. I have a photo of Jackie Cain that he took.

MR: Oh, Jackie.

BK: It's a wonderful photo. I'll see if I can email it to you.

MR: I'd love that. Thank you. Yeah I was honored one time because he took a picture of me. And I just felt so — it made me feel wonderful.

BK: Oh sure. Yeah.

MR: So lastly, this is sort of an odd question but musically or politically or in any regard, is there something that could come up in a conversation that would really get, I guess the phrase is get your dander up? That would make you respond emphatically and be angry?

BK: Well in part I feel like my generation has been kind of overlooked, the generation that came up in the 70s. You know I won't go into naming names but I think you understand what I'm talking about. You know I feel like there was a whole generation of people who came up when I did in the 70s and our contributions have largely been overlooked. You know and we didn't get a lot of the opportunities we should have. So that, you know, when, or for example I told you earlier about all the stuff I heard in New York in the 70s, in the early 70s you know and often you hear it written and said by various people who don't know, who weren't there, who say that oh there was nothing happening in jazz in the 70s, you know it was this period of doldrums. And that is total crap. I mean I mentioned all the things that I heard in New York in the 70s and that was a fraction of what was going on. There was so much happening at that point, but you had to be there to know about it, and all these people who weren't there are going around saying that it never happened. It's being erased in almost Orwellian fashion. And that, as a jazz historian, pisses me off you know I mean whenever I get a chance to correct that I'm very vocal about that because I think it's important that people get recognition for what they've done, which, and for example I'm glad that you've been doing all these interviews for 25, 30 years. I mean you've interviewed a lot of people who otherwise would not have gotten that recognition or gotten the chance to tell their stories. And it's important that gets done.

MR: Well it's been a great gig for me, and I appreciate your time today, and there's a lot more we can touch on and maybe we'll do so again. And I thank you for your time.

BK: Oh my pleasure, are you kidding? Thank you for doing this. It's an honor.

MR: Well great. I hope we can cross paths. You know I usually do these things face to face but obviously we deal with the times we're in.

BK: Yeah. Well you know I mean Zoom has been a lifesaver in so many ways. I mean it's basically enabled us to keep our education system going during this past year or so whereas otherwise things would have come to a screeching halt. So I mean that's been important. And you know also I mean it enables, you've done a number of these interviews lately on Zoom that you wouldn't have had a chance to do face to face. So I mean that was a good move on your part just to switch to that medium.

MR: Well I'm going to pause our recording and I hope whatever arrangement is bouncing around in your head after we're doing reaches a fine conclusion.

BK: Thank you. If you get to New York, for whatever reason, please let me know and let's hook up.

MR: Okay. Thanks a lot, Bill.

BK: Thank you. Take good care.